

features ■ firsthand

ILLUSTRATION: Atul
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COMPUTING FOR Absolutely Everybody

“Our vision when we started the company was a computer on every desk and in every home.

In this setting, I think the word to emphasise is ‘Every’. The PC can be a tool for every

Hari Raghavan, aged 24, comes across as your regular MBA yuppie, sporting a clean shave and an endearing twang. What makes his colleagues take a double take as he marches into his office is the red and white stick he uses. ‘Challenged’ by retinal degeneration since the age of 17, Raghavan is a marketing executive with one of India’s leading publishing houses. His job profile involves two extremely sight-centred activities—computing and travelling. Thanks to special tools built into common applications and some add-ons, he is able to do his work remarkably well within the same setup that is used by the rest of the office.

In the overall employment and market scenario, where every half a degree separates the employed from the unemployed, physical impairment can be a big drawback—especially so if it is of the visual nature. In a workplace, the employment of any differently abled individual means extra investment in terms of infrastructure and hence, the choice

between hiring an able-bodied person and a blind one is already made. In this kind of economy, especially in a developing country, it is quite a struggle for the disabled to acquire jobs. In order to amend this, it is essential that they are educated by the same standard and have similar skill sets as others so that they can easily fit into existing work environments.

The need then is for chameleon like devices and applications that blend in with the already existing environment. Fortunately, there are plenty of tools available that allow this.

Inherent support

The source of input and feedback is the most crucial part of an application for those who are incapable of receiving conventional feedback. This naturally points to Braille, the tried and tested medium of communication. However, a basic drawback with Braille is the learning curve involved, not to mention the ‘unlearning’ one has to do of conventional reading and writing

methods. This is especially difficult for those who have lost their sight gradually or by an accident.

K. Ramakrishna, a general manager at IDBI bank, found that Braille was inadequate for his mathematical and statistical requirements. “Not that the teachers at the National Association for the Blind didn’t try their very best to teach me Braille,” says he with a snigger, ‘I think I was just too lazy to learn.’”

Also, the introduction of, say, Braille printer or keyboard in a functional workplace spells additional effort, which few are ready to undertake. However, this same crack lets in the light for computing—since Braille has such limitations, we have to fall back upon regular alphabet reading. For those who already have the concept of a PC and its navigation, OCR and screen reading software are ideal.

Visual disability can be classified as either partial or complete blindness. The former obviously lends a certain degree of independence compared to the latter. It